“present” for Mikoyan, arriving at the embassy immediately after visiting a Cuban antiaircraft battery in Havana, where he gave the order to resume shooting at low-flying American airplanes.

The actual order was signed on November 17, the day after Castro attended Mikoyan’s dinner, and it instructed the antiaircraft units to open fire on intruders starting at 6:00 a.m. on November 18. It was the first such order since October 27, when the Soviets had downed the U-2. Castro also sent U Thant a long letter rejecting any form of inspection on Cuban territory and protesting American overflights.

On hearing what Castro had just done, Mikoyan protested: why had he not been informed? Castro was defiant if not stubborn: they had discussed a letter to U Thant previously, and he was not going to cancel his order, which had already been given. Mikoyan’s attempt to convince Castro, Che Guevara, and other Cuban leaders present at the dinner that the Americans would never pledge not to invade Cuba if they were shot at proved futile. With Castro’s order in place, the threat of military conflict over Cuba that everyone believed to have passed returned with new force.[10]

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On November 12, Anatoly Dobrynin handed Robert Kennedy a missive from the Kremlin. In a typically lengthy letter, Khrushchev proposed what amounted to a Turkish-type solution to the bomber problem, offering the president his word that the bombers would be removed in the future. “We will not insist on permanently keeping those planes in Cuba,” wrote Khrushchev. “We have our difficulties in this question. Therefore, we give a gentleman’s word that we will remove the IL-28 planes with all the personnel and equipment related to those planes, although not now but later.”[11]

Robert Kennedy, to whom Dobrynin passed Khrushchev’s message along with Khrushchev’s oral congratulations to Kennedy on his successful midterm elections, was skeptical about the Soviet leader’s proposal. He wanted the Soviets to announce publicly the date on which they would remove the bombers; once the announcement was made, the naval blockade